being essential for global governance.[56] The benefits of such rules and multilateral cooperation could even be maintained "after hegemony."[57] Within the basic rules structure, as Ruggie suggests, new powerful actors, such as the BRICS, can promote new instruments, including the NDB and AIIB. Hence, despite the diffusion of international power, a benign, rules-based system has an appeal even to modernizing, authoritarian countries such as China and Russia, for providing stability and serving their interest in economic investment and growth. In this context, China is characterized as a "reform-minded status quo state" which "accepts the existing rules"[58] and "isn't interested in changing the international order but rather in maximizing and leveraging its growing interests to shape the existing order to further its interests."[59] Similarly, according to the director of the Russian International Affairs Council, "There is currently no consistent, comprehensive, and fully detailed alternative to the liberal world order."[60]

The *joiner* thesis is most strongly countered by hard-core realists who contend that rising powers will eventually be driven to challenge status quo powers as *spoilers* and may even provoke the historical pattern of wrenching power transitions.[61] Even moderate realists recognize that shifts in the distribution of power diminish the attractiveness and soft power of incumbent institutions given the capacities of emerging powers such as China allow them to act without the United States as competitors to the World Bank and IMF.[62] Other observers suggest that the BRICS have nothing positive to offer global governance, in that they essentially behave as free riders and as *shirkers*, with the likely result a G-Zero world where there is greater fragmentation and little productive cooperation to solve international problems.[63]

This book finds all three of these images—of *joiners, spoilers, or shirkers*—to be only partial representations or unpersuasive. While the BRICS, as a group, certainly are revisionists, and thus not straightforward *joiners*, they are neither *spoilers* nor currently *shirkers*. Earlier concerns about free-riding appear less compelling since the considerable cooperation of the BRICs in the G20 and IMF to ameliorate the global financial crisis of 2008–2009 and other policy changes on currency valuation and combating climate change. Moreover, the diffusion of power that results in shifts in certain capabilities does not inevitably lead to violent power transitions, which are improbable in the nuclear era.[64] BRICS acting individually have